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**THE ILLUSION OF DIFFERENCE: CULTURAL ADAPTATION IN
EUROPEAN WEBSITES**

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ABSTRACT

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This study examines how companies balance standardization and localization in the context of website communication across European cultures, with a comparative focus on Italy and Sweden. Prior research emphasizes the importance of cultural adaptation, but it often lacks actionable advice for managers and instead relies heavily on theoretical frameworks (such as Hofstede's and Hall's cultural dimensions). To bridge this gap, this report conducts a comparative content analysis of five multinational companies: IKEA, Volkswagen, Verisure, Wix, and Deloitte. 22 website elements are evaluated using an adapted coding framework based on cultural theory. Each element is scored on a three-point scale (0-2) across a sample of 40 website pages to examine both presence and emphasis. The analysis finds that there is an overall preference for standardization. Only minor degrees of localization are observed. Cultural differences are not shown in the complete redesign of websites but through a small number of high-impact elements: prestige claims, male-dominant imagery, and multi-stimulus environments. These express the highest degree of sensitivity to cultural differences, while UX elements are universally standardized. Using the findings, the study introduces a three-tier decision framework that categorizes elements into "Localize," "Standardize," and "Monitor" recommendations. Moreover, the results show weak alignment with traditional culture frameworks, which suggests that modern digital standards may override cultural differences in web design. The report recommends a selective localization strategy so managers can focus resources on a small number of elements and maintain global brand consistency. Ultimately, the results challenge the assumption that extensive localization is necessary in European markets. The author instead advocates for a targeted adaptation for maximizing effectiveness and cost efficiency in digital communication.

The undersigned, Jakob Wennerqvist, with student ID number 2035050, requests to defend the final thesis of the Master's degree in Business Administration in the session of April 2026. The undersigned, under their own responsibility, declares that the entire text of the final thesis has been produced by the undersigned, and that all paper and electronic sources consulted for its completion have always been properly referenced by the undersigned within the thesis itself, both in the case of direct quotations (whether short or long, in the original language or translated), all of which have been enclosed in quotation marks, and in the case of indirect quotations.

Signature: _____

Acknowledgments/Dedications

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Introduction

Background

Ever since the introduction of the internet, brands have asked themselves how to reach their digital customers most effectively. Trial and error with a splash of Darwinism eventually led to companies developing a set of communication and marketing tactics that worked extremely well for them. And as borders got more diffuse, brands believed their strategies would work just as smoothly in the country next door. There is a saying that goes “Don’t fix it if it ain’t broke,” so that is what brands did—they did not change their communication because they did not see a problem. But as these brands acquired more diverse customers, the complexity of this problem only compounded. And as the next-door neighboring country led to another next-door neighbor, the expectations of the customers became potentially exponentially divergent.

Many brands have realized the complexity of their consumer base and partially localized their business activities accordingly. The consensus in the literature is that there is generally a high need for localization when global brands communicate with local consumers. Noris et al. (2025) define localization (also known as adaptation) as “the adaptation of products and content to fit the cultural preferences of specific markets.” Standardization, on the other hand, “enables companies to streamline processes and enhance cost-efficiency across homogeneous global markets” (Noris et al., 2025). Firstly, brands need to communicate in the local language. Rashkova et al. (2023) argue that there is a distinction between “duplication of meaning” (standardization with translation) and transferring meaning to fit both the language and the culture (localization). But will a simple translation of meaning be enough to tailor messaging to each unique culture? The current marketing literature is unified: a combination of standardization and adaptation is the way to go. Companies seldom pick either total standardization or pure localization across all communication channels (Vrontis & Thrassou, 2007), and success often comes from a hybrid strategy (Vrontis, 2003). Eze et al. (2024) reinforce this notion by encouraging firms to standardize brand and core features while adapting to cultural, legal, and economic conditions. Vrontis & Thrassou (2007) concur by stating that culture is the driving factor in the adaptation of marketing activities.

For many years, people believed that the internet and globalization would lead to the formation of standardized consumer preferences (De Mooij, 2019). The

macroeconomic argument is that as countries become wealthier and economically integrated, their consumer behaviors will inevitably converge. From a Homo Economicus perspective, if everyone has the same amount of disposable income, they should spend it on the same things because they are purely rational beings seeking high quality and low prices (Levitt, 1983). However, this notion could not be more inaccurate. Globalization has merely visualized the cultural diversity of the world (De Mooij, 2019). The internet works as a culture megaphone, instead of a funnel of unity. While messaging apps have given people the possibility to connect with people on the other side of the world, the research shows that these apps have primarily made people communicate more frequently with the people in their community (De Mooij, 2019).

The sample principle can be applied to younger generations who grew up with modern technology. A 25-year-old graphic designer in Milan, Italy, who subscribes to Adobe Creative Cloud might not be doing so with the same cultural motivations as a 25-year-old graphic designer in Gothenburg, Sweden. Demographic overlap does not equal cultural overlap. At a macroeconomic level, everyone in Europe more or less converges since everyone's basic utilities are met. Close to everyone has a fridge, a TV, and a car in the household. But on a micro level, they spend their excess disposable income in drastically diverse ways. De Mooij (2019) categorizes culture into software and hardware. Hardware is the functional attributes of the product. These cross borders easily. Software, on the other hand, is the motivation behind the purchase; how the consumers negotiate, how they perceive authority, and what they do the moment they return to their local environment. This aspect is highly culturally bound. Therefore, if a company is standardizing its value proposition across borders, it is marketing a scarcity-level utility to a post-scarcity consumer.

On the flip side of the coin, Schmid & Kotulla (2011) argue that the efficiency of standardization may outweigh the pros of localization if one or multiple of the following characteristics are met: "high cross-national homogeneity of demand, (2) a high potential for cross-national economies of scale, (3) a high cost of product modification, (4) a high foreign price elasticity of demand, (5) a small perceptual error of the managers, and (6) a high quality of strategy execution."

Hence, in the cultural standardization versus adaptation discourse, there is a constant battle between the potential of economies of scale and the cost of adaptation. In other words, will adapting a website to fit the local culture generate more value than

what it costs to implement? In this paper, the standpoint of profit maximization is assumed. Therefore, all actions of adaptation must be weighed against the potential costs they may bring. If a localization of a certain website element has a net negative impact, then standardization is the clear winner.

Purpose

Prior research has extensively focused on cultural differences between countries on different continents and has primarily presented what differences exist, but has failed to give concrete actionable insights to managers. However, most international expansion of business activities is not intercontinental, but rather intracontinental (Rugman & Verbeke, 2004). In light of this, the purpose of this research paper is to help managers who are expanding intracontinentally decide what to standardize and what to localize in order to enhance effectiveness in communication, minimize costs, and ultimately maximize profitability. This paper conducts a comparative case study of five internationally established companies of differing sectors and applies a contingency approach, which is a management theory that entails that managerial decisions should be made with the unique situation of the company in mind. The following research question forms the basis of this study: *How should companies decide which marketing elements to standardize vs. localize across European cultures?* This question is followed by a set of sub-questions: *Which marketing elements are most sensitive to cultural differences? What are the risks of over-localizing vs. under-localizing? How do brands currently balance global brand consistency with cultural adaptation? Which of Hofstede's and Hall's dimensions are most important to localize in website communication?*

Literature Review

Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions

Culture is a complex and intangible topic, which means that predicting behavior based on culture is a difficult task. Hofstede (1984) presents a framework that reduces the complexity down to six dimensions: Power Distance, Individualism, Uncertainty Avoidance, Motivation towards Masculinity and Success, Long Term Orientation, and Indulgence. Each dimension is applied to a country on a 0-100 scale. This model was developed using a large-scale comparison of countries using employee survey data from IBM, and it has become one of the most widely accepted and used descriptions of cultural differences (Hofstede et al, 2010). However, the framework has been criticized for using the assumption that every country has a single homogenous culture, and there are also concerns surrounding the fact that the data primarily comes from a workplace context.

Power Distance (PDI)

This dimension covers the notion that individuals in the culture are unequal and measures the attitude of the people towards this inequality. Power distance can also be defined as “the extent to which the less powerful members of institutions and organizations within a country expect and accept that power is distributed unequally” (The Culture Factor Group, 2026). In business settings, cultures with high power distance tend to materialize in hierarchical organizational structures and high respect for authority.

Though Italy (50) scores higher than Sweden (31), neither country scores particularly high in this dimension. This would suggest Italian website design should put slightly more emphasis on leadership visibility, credibility from institutions, and prestige language.

Individualism (IDV)

The individualism dimension measures the degree of interdependence between members of a society. This aspect is strongly linked with self-image and whether people in the culture associate it with “I” or “we.” Members of individualistic cultures solely look out for themselves and their direct families, while members of collectivistic

cultures associate themselves with in-groups that care for them and to which they are loyal.

There is a significant distinction between the two countries in this category. Sweden (83) is substantially more individualistic (compared to Italy's score of 53) according to this framework. This entails that Swedes favor the individual's success over the collective's, and bonds between people are weaker. In digital communication and web design, the implications of this dimension may be observed through the extensive use of images of individuals (as opposed to images of groups of people), and language centered around "you" or "I" (as opposed to "we") (Cruz et al., 2017).

Motivation towards Achievement and Success (MAS)

High MAS scores illustrate that the culture promotes competition, achievement, and success. Members reach success by distinguishing themselves as a winner or "best in the field." A low MAS score indicates that caring for others and quality of life are valued higher. Standing out from the crowd is not seen as something desirable and commendable. The key distinction between these two extremes is whether people are motivated by "wanting to be the best" or "liking what you do" (The Culture Factor Group, 2026). This dimension was initially called "Masculinity," but the name was adapted to the current version in 2023 because it was seen as outdated and tied to binary gender ideas (Worthy et al., n.d.). The new name more closely matches what the dimension measures, and the meaning of the dimension itself has therefore remained consistent.

This is where the greatest gap between the two cultures emerges. Sweden (5) has one of the lowest scores of any country in this dimension, while Italy (70) scores highly. This entails that Italians are more driven towards success and career development, whereas Swedes prefer activities that promote quality of life and job satisfaction. In web design this dimension may be measured by the degree of language centered around achievement and success, as well as the degree to which competition and performance are emphasized.

Uncertainty Avoidance (UAI)

This dimension measures the attitude towards the fact that the future is unknown. The core question is: should we try to control the future or just let it happen? (The Culture Factor Group, 2026). An uncertainty-avoidant culture feels threatened by

ambiguity and has therefore established beliefs and methods to try to dodge this. In the workplace, this can be seen in standardization and safety measures.

Italy (75) is defined as a risk-averse country that dislikes unclear situations, while Sweden (25) tallies a low score, which indicates that the people have a positive inclination towards change and innovation. Web design-wise, this dimension assumes that Italian websites will have more language surrounding, minimizing risks, such as help sections, clear step-by-step instructions, and guarantees (Ganguly et al., 2010).

Long Term Orientation (LTO)

Every individual in every culture has to deal with the three perspectives of being: past, present, and future. The ties between the past, the present, and the future have varying degrees of strength depending on the culture. Societies with low scores are skeptical of societal change and prefer time-bound traditions and norms. Cultures that score highly on this dimension, on the other hand, welcome change and modernization as a means to prepare for the future.

Sweden (51) comes in at an average score, whereas Italy (39) scores slightly below that. This indicates that there will only be minor differences in elements such as future-oriented and planning messaging.

Indulgence (IVR)

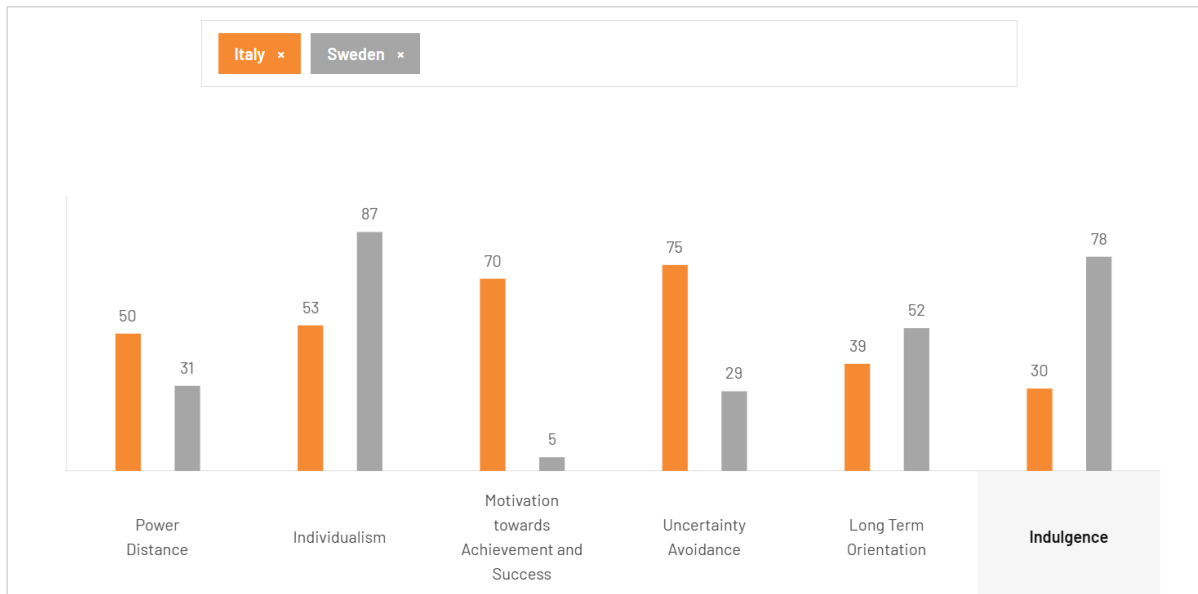
The indulgence dimension is the latest addition to the framework and is described as the degree to which people try to hamper their own instincts, desires, and impulses. Weak control is called “Indulgence,” and strong discipline is referred to as “Restraint” (The Culture Factor Group, 2026). The dimension was introduced in 2010 and is based on World Values Survey data (Hofstede et al., 2010).

Sweden (78) scores highly, which illustrates a preference for gratification. Italy (30), on the other hand, is assigned a low score that points towards a culture that promotes restraint.

Because this dimension was introduced almost 30 years after the other dimensions, it is excluded from many web design frameworks for consistency purposes (e.g. Singh & Matsuo, 2004; Capece & Di Pillo, 2023). Additionally, indulgence may not materialize prominently in this kind of communication and is therefore excluded.

Figure 1: Hofstede's Theoretical Scores of Italy and Sweden

(Scores and graphic from The Culture Factor Group (2026))



Hall's Cultural Dimensions

Another well-established framework for interpreting and comparing cultures is Hall's (1976) High Context vs. Low Context and Polychronism vs. Monochronism models. Hall argues that human behavior is applied through the lenses of informal norms of time and space.

High Context vs. Low Context Cultures

This theory treads the line between verbal and non-verbal cues. In low-context cultures, meaning is transferred almost completely by explicit verbal and written means. Contracts and documents, therefore, play a crucial role in negotiations. In a high-context culture, on the other hand, meaning is to a larger extent conveyed implicitly. Context and relationships are substantially more important than words. As opposed to Hofstede's (1984) model that assigns scores to each country, Hall's (1976) framework is purely relativity-based and places each country on a spectrum. In this spectrum, as seen in Table 1, Italy is placed in the high context section, alongside Spain, Portugal, and France, while Sweden can be found among some of the lowest context cultures (other Scandinavian countries and North America) (Van Everdingen & Waarts, 2003).

Effective website communication is hypothesized to match these dimensions. Italy should score higher than Sweden on aspects such as complex designs, visual density, animations, and many layers and sections, which all indicate high context.

Table 1: Low and High Context Countries and their Characteristics

(Table from Van Everdingen & Waarts (2003))

	Scale score	Countries	Characteristics	Expected influence on adoption of innovations
Low context	1	Germans, Swiss, Austrians	• Message is made explicit • Interpretation of messages rests on the written or spoken word – focus on content • Seek information from a research base (reports, databases, internet, etc.)	Negative H6
	2	New Zealanders, (white) South Africans		
	3	North Americans (white Anglo-Saxon Protestant) and Canadians		
	4	Scandinavians, Finns		
	5	British, Australians		
	6	Benelux people		
	7	Other American cultures		
	8	Slavs		
High context	9	Central Europeans	• Interpretation of messages rests on contextual cues • Seek information from personal information networks • Becoming well-informed about the facts before making a decisions	
	10	Koreans, South East Asians		
	11	Indians, and other Indian sub-continent		
	12	Arabs, Africans		
	13	Latin Americans		
	14	Italians, Spanish, Portuguese, French, Other Mediterranean peoples		
	15	Chinese		
	16	Japanese		

Based on Morden, 1999; Usunier, 2000; Kotabe and Helsen, 2001.

Polychronic vs. Monochronic Cultures

The concept of time is a relative term in the realm of cultural comparison. Polychronic time is characteristic of cultures where punctuality is of less importance, and flexibility and distractions from the objective are welcomed. Additionally, changes to the itinerary are usual, and multiple activities can be performed at once. Monochronic cultures emphasize one activity at a time, making detailed plans and executing them. Time is regarded as a resource that should be rationed, carefully arranged, and used sparingly.

Italy is considered a polychronic country, along with other Mediterranean countries, Arabs, and Latin Americans, as seen in Table 2. Noteworthy here is that Italian culture is split into Northern Italian and Southern Italian, illustrating the intranational cultural differences that exist in many countries. Northern Italian culture, while still being considered polychronic, is located closer to the monochronic cultures on the scale, whereas Southern Italy is categorized among Spain and India. Sweden resides close to the monochronic extreme with countries such as England, Canada, and Finland.

While Hall's two frameworks are similar, there are some differences. For example, France is not classified alongside its Mediterranean neighbors and can instead be found on the monochronic side among Walloon Belgium and Korea.

In marketing, Hall's dimensions should theoretically match the culture that the communication is trying to reach. Italian websites should therefore reflect a higher degree of polychronic web design cues. These cues may involve elements such as multi-stimulus pages and a structure with multiple paths and layers.

Table 2: Monochronic and Polychronic Countries with their Characteristics.

(Table from Van Everdingen & Waarts (2003))

	Scale score	Countries	Characteristics	Expected influence on adoption of innovations
Mono-chronic	1	Germans, Swiss, Austrians	- Plans ahead methodically - Does one thing at a time - Punctual - Sticks to plans - Sticks to facts - Gets info from statistics, reference books, database - Works within department - Focused communication, to the point - Writes memoranda, uses written record	Negative H7
	2	Americans (White Anglo-Saxon Protestant)		
	3	Scandinavians, Finns		
	4	British, Canadians, New Zealanders		
	5	Australians, (white) South Africans		
	6	Japanese		
	7	Dutch, Flemish Belgian		
	8	Other American cultures		
	9	French, Walloon Belgium		
	10	Koreans, Taiwanese, Singaporeans		
Poly-chronic	11	Czechs, Slovaks, Slovenians, Croats, Hungarians	- Plans grand outline / “vision” - Does several things at once - Unpunctual - Changes plans - Juggles facts - Gets first-hand oral information - Goes round all departments - Talks for hours - Dislikes writing too much, prefers flexibility to commitment	
	12	Chines		
	13	Northern Italians		
	14	Chile		
	15	Other Slavs		
	16	Portuguese		
	17	Spanish, Southern Italians, Other Mediterranean people		
	18	Indians, and other Indian sub-continent		
	19	Polynesians		
	20	Latin Americans, Arabs, Africans		

Based on Morden, 1999; Kotabe and Helsen, 2001.

Methodology

In this paper, a comparative content analysis is used to evaluate the degree and type of differentiation between websites in two distinctly different cultures. By analyzing the same brands in two culturally distinct markets, the approach controls for brand-specific factors and focuses on differences in culture, which enables a structured evaluation of localization practices.

Coding Framework

The coding framework used in the analysis is an adaptation of Capece & Di Pillo's (2023) and Singh & Matsuo's (2010) frameworks that integrate Hofstede's and Hall's cultural dimensions to measure website design localization. Hofstede's (1984) *Indulgence* dimension is excluded from both Capece & Di Pillo's (2023) and Singh & Matsuo's (2010) coding frameworks because of limited objectivity and applicability when evaluating website design and communication. Thus, the dimension has been excluded from this analysis as well.

While prior studies primarily rely on binary presence or absence coding, this approach limits the ability to capture subtle differences in emphasis and execution. To address this limitation, this study applies a three-point scale (0–2), where 0 indicates absence, 1 indicates peripheral presence (e.g. below the fold, in small text, in the footer), and 2 indicates strong and prominent presence (e.g. headline, hero section, main visuals, central messaging). Large headlines and visuals, repeated messaging, and communication related to the core value proposition all indicate a strong presence. For example, a “free trial” message placed prominently in the hero section would be coded as strong presence (2), whereas the same message located in the footer or fine print would be coded as weak presence (1). This allows for a more nuanced evaluation of how cultural signals are expressed across websites. The framework shown in Table 3 has been adapted to reflect contemporary web design practices. Outdated or irrelevant indicators have been replaced with modern equivalents while preserving their underlying theoretical foundation. The full set of adaptations and justifications is provided in Appendix 1.

Table 3: Coding Framework Aligned with Hofstede's and Hall's Theories

(With description of what each indicator observes | Adapted from Capece & Di Pillo's (2023) coding framework.)

Indicator	What it Observes
Power Distance Index	
Leadership / authority visibility	CEO, founder, expert, executive presence
Institutional credibility	Awards, certifications, major client logos, partner logos
Prestige / leadership claims	"Leader," "trusted by industry," "#1"
Individualism Index	
Individual imagery	One person alone, individual use scenes
Individual benefit framing	"Your success," "your website," "your goals"
Motivation towards Achievement and Success Index	
Male-dominant imagery	Men shown alone or as primary actors
Achievement language	Success, winning, growth, performance
Competitive framing	"Outperform," "be the best," "lead"
Performance emphasis	Efficiency, results, effectiveness
Uncertainty Avoidance Index	
Help/support visibility	FAQ, chat, contact, customer service
Navigation clarity	Clear menus, structured pathways, easy next steps
Trial/guarantee mechanisms	Free trial, cancel anytime, refunds, free downloads
Process explanation	"How it works," step-by-step onboarding
Long Term Orientation Index	
Search / structured discovery tools	Search bar, structured menus, filtering
Information depth	FAQ, explanatory content, layered details
Future-oriented messaging	Build for the future, long-term growth, enduring value
Stability/sustainability framing	Reliable, long-lasting, strategic investment
High Context Index	
Visual richness / density	Dense page, many visual layers, expressive design
Multimedia / motion	Video, animation, movement, dynamic hero sections
Layered / non-linear structure	Multiple paths, rich sections, more exploratory flow
Polychronism Index	
Multi-Stimulus Environment	Presence of more than one simultaneous visual and interactive elements (animations, video, banners, pop-ups, moving components)
Layered / Non-Linear Structure	Multiple paths, rich sections, more exploratory flow

Sample Selection

The countries, Italy and Sweden, were picked based on their significant cultural distance. As seen in Hofstede's theory, the two countries tally substantially different scores with a mean absolute delta of 31.8 across all six dimensions (calculated using data from The Culture Factor Group, 2026). The same level of divergence is present in Hall's theory. While this theory does not provide a scoring system for cultural differences, Italy (North and South) prominently ranks on the Polychronism and High context side of the spectrum, and Sweden ranks close to the opposite extremes (Van Everdingen & Waarts, 2003). What these theories further show is the cultural similarities between geographically neighboring countries. For example, Sweden is grouped with other Scandinavian countries in Hall's dimensions, and Hofstede assigns similar dimensional scores to other Mediterranean countries. The mean absolute difference between Italy and France is 13.5, and the mean absolute difference between Sweden and Norway is 11.2. This is closely interconnected to the idea of cultural clusters, which was introduced by the GLOBE project and is one of the most widely used classifications of culture (House et al., 2004). There are ten cultural clusters, and Italy can be located in the Latin cluster alongside Spain, France, and Portugal, while Sweden belongs to the Nordic cluster with Denmark, Norway, and Finland. Given these similarities with neighboring countries, this sample selection aims to provide broader generalizations about the differences between the Latin and Nordic clusters through the lens of Sweden and Italy.

A limitation of the three-point (0-2) scale is that coding requires more time, and the analysis has therefore been applied to a smaller number of cases and a smaller number of pages. The sample size used in this analysis is 5 brands, which have one website for each of the two countries ($n=10$ websites). For each website, 4 core pages are analyzed, which brings the total number of pages to 40. These four page types were selected based on possessing comparable touchpoints across company sectors and represent key stages in the customer decision-making process. The first and perhaps most crucial page type is the home/landing page, which provides the first impression and acts as a strong cultural signaling page and therefore is often highly localized. The second page type is a form of pricing, booking, or purchase page. On this page, differing degrees of uncertainty avoidance are hypothesized to be expressed. The third page type is a "how it works," or a product or service explanation page. Communication

style, depth, and structure of explanations often shine through on this page. Lastly, the trust, social proof, FAQ, or support page. This type of page reveals degrees of individualism, power distance, and credibility signals. See Appendix 2 for exact URLs analyzed.

To provide generalizable insights about marketing communications on websites, companies from a wide array of sectors were selected. The set of companies ranges from purely physical products (IKEA and its furniture) to exclusively service-oriented/advisory offerings (Deloitte and its consulting services), as displayed in Figure 2. The following companies were selected: IKEA, Volkswagen, Verisure, Wix, and Deloitte. This set also provides a combination of B2C and B2B business models. All companies sell to businesses in varying degrees; however, Deloitte is the outlier since it does not offer services for consumers.

Figure 2: Positioning Firms Along the Product–Service Continuum
 (A comparative classification of selected companies based on the tangibility of their core offerings, ranging from physical products to intangible services.)



Data Collection

All websites were accessed using incognito mode and translated into English using the built-in translation tool in the Google Chrome browser. The websites were analyzed in the following country- and company-alternating pattern to minimize potential for coder bias and subjectivity in evaluations across brands and countries: Wix Italy, Verisure Sweden, Volkswagen Italy, Deloitte Sweden, IKEA Italy, Wix Italy, Verisure Italy, Volkswagen Sweden, Deloitte Italy, IKEA Sweden.

Male-dominant imagery was calculated by tallying the total number of men depicted on the website and comparing it to the total number of images with people. Individual versus collective imagery was calculated in the same vein; images with individuals were divided by the total number of images depicting people. A quotient of <0.5 was assigned a 0, ≥ 0.5 received a 1, and results of ≥ 0.75 were given a 2.

The scores were subsequently averaged interdimensionally to be applied to Hofstede's country scores. To ensure the 0-2 score average could be compared to Hofstede's 0-100 scales, the averages were converted to a 0-100 scale by multiplying the averages by 50. For example, a score of 1.25 multiplied by 50 becomes 62.5.

The degree of brand localization is calculated using the absolute value of the difference between the Italian and the Swedish versions of the website across the dimension averages. This generates a scale from 0 (complete standardization, all elements are perfectly aligned) to 10 (complete localization, all elements are unconditionally different).

A robustness check was carried out by excluding one brand at a time to observe potential substantial changes in the aggregated data. After each brand was individually excluded from the rest, the brand that resulted in the biggest shift in the dataset while excluded (IKEA) was used to illustrate an inclusion vs. exclusion robustness check (see Table 8). Only website elements that "survived" this robustness check were then included in the decision framework.

Analysis

Degree of Standardization/Localization

The analysis clearly illustrates the level of standardization versus localization that brands apply through measuring the absolute difference between the Italian and Swedish website versions for each website element, averaging across each cultural dimension, and adding up the total number. Table 4 shows the data alongside a note about what strategy each brand utilizes.

Table 4: Brand Standardization Index

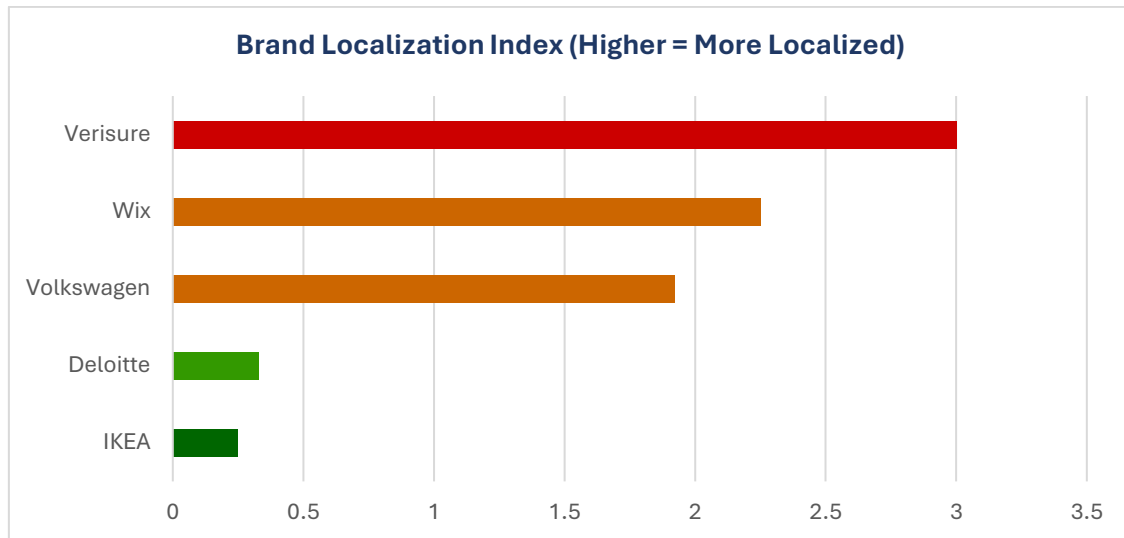
(Absolute difference |Italy – Sweden| per dimension, 0-2 scale. Lower = more standardized)

Brand	PDI	IDV	MAS	UAI	LTO	HC + POL	Total $ \Delta $	Strategy
IKEA	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.25	0.00	0.25	Near-Total Standardization
Deloitte	0.33	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.33	Near-Total Standardization
Volkswagen	0.33	0.00	0.25	0.25	0.25	0.83	1.92	Moderate Localization
Wix	0.00	0.50	0.50	0.00	0.25	1.00	2.25	Moderate Localization
Verisure	0.67	1.00	0.00	0.00	0.50	0.83	3	Highest Localization

2 of 5 brands (IKEA and Deloitte) show near-total standardization of elements between their Italian and Swedish websites. While there still are visual and structural differences between the websites, when observing the versions using the elements from the adapted framework, the differences dissolve. Figure 3 visualizes the degree of localization. Even the most localized brand in this sample (Verisure) indicates a modest degree of adaptation (a score of 3 on a 0-12 scale). This proposes a strong favoritism towards standardization in European website communication. Localization can, therefore, in this small sample, be seen more as the exception than the rule.

Figure 3: Brand Localization Index

(Comparative index showing the degree to which selected firms adapt their websites to local markets. Higher = more localized)

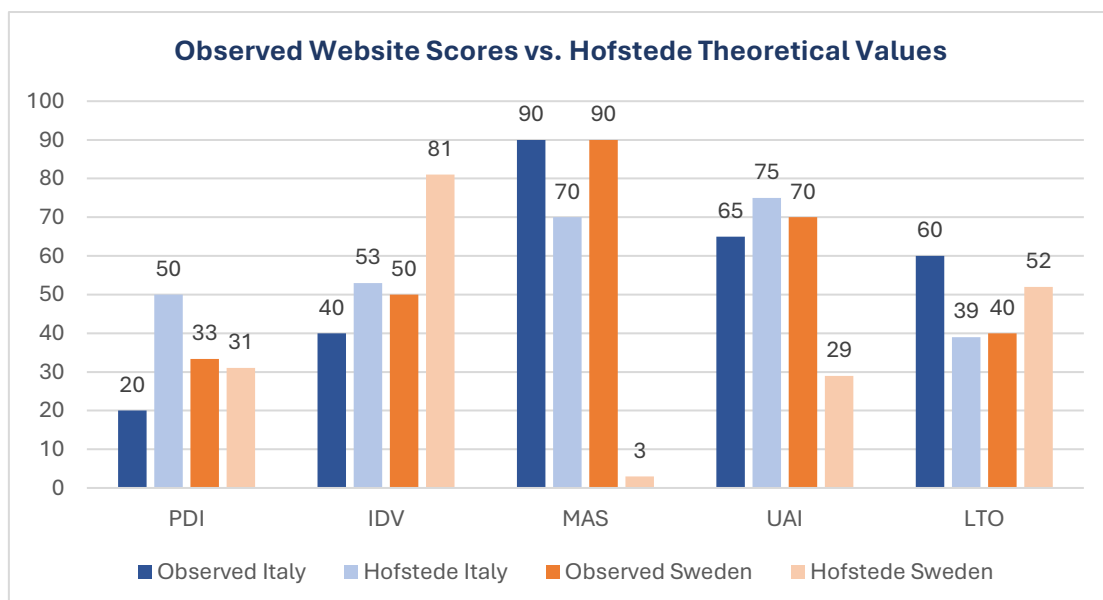


Comparison to Theoretical Frameworks

To test the applicability of Hofstede's and Hall's cultural dimensions, observed score averages are compared to theory-based country scores in Figure 4.

Figure 4: Observed Website Scores vs. Hofstede Theoretical Values

(Comparison of empirically derived website scores with Hofstede's cultural dimension values for Italy and Sweden. 0-100 scale with high scores indicating high alignment with the dimension.)



The observed companies treat Swedish users as highly uncertainty-avoidant, despite their country's theoretical high tolerance for risk. One plausible explanation can be how websites often include messages that reduce friction in the customer journey

(Ganguly et al., 2010). Sweden's observed high MAS score (90 instead of 3) indicates that achievement and performance language persists even though Sweden is theoretically the most feminine country in the world. Italy shows significantly less achievement and success language than its theoretical prediction. The PDI score for Italian websites is substantially lower than expected (Observed: 20, Hofstede: 50).

Further, in Table 5, the results' alignment with theory is tested by analyzing the observed directional results with what the theory predicts. Directional alignment/consistency is achieved when the observations show the same relative trend between the countries as the theory suggests. For instance, if Italy scores higher than Sweden in Power Distance according to the theory, one expects the same trend to follow for the observations. Consequently, if the observed sample of Italian websites scores higher than that of Sweden, there is directional consistency. If the scores are nearly identical or the directional relationship is inverted, there is directional inconsistency.

Table 5: Observed Directional Consistency between Website Scores and Hofstede Theoretical Values

(Observed scores transformed to 0–100 scale for comparison with Hofstede's country scores)

Dim.	Observed Italy	Hofstede Italy	Observed Sweden	Hofstede Sweden	Observed Direction	Hofstede Direction	Directional Alignment
PDI	20	50	33	31	SE > IT	IT > SE	INCONSISTENT
IDV	40	53	50	81	SE > IT	SE > IT	CONSISTENT
MAS	90	70	90	3	SE ≈ IT	IT >> SE	INCONSISTENT
UAI	65	75	70	29	SE ≈ IT	IT >> SE	INCONSISTENT
LTO	60	39	40	52	SE > IT	SE > IT	INCONSISTENT

Only 1 out of Hofstede's 5 analyzed dimensions (IDV and LTO) show directional consistency between observations and theoretical values. The largest gap between theory and observation is found in the MAS dimension. Hofstede assigns Italy a score of 70 and Sweden a score of 3 (a 63-point gap). Observations show, however, a minimal gap with both scoring 90 and both deviating far from theory (Sweden deviates by 87 points). UAI is another diverging dimension. Both countries coincide relatively close to the Italian theoretical score (75), when Hofstede argues that Sweden should be substantially lower.

Directional alignment is also compared in the context of high context and polychronism dimensions. In Table 6, both individual website elements and aggregate dimensional scores are checked for alignment with theory.

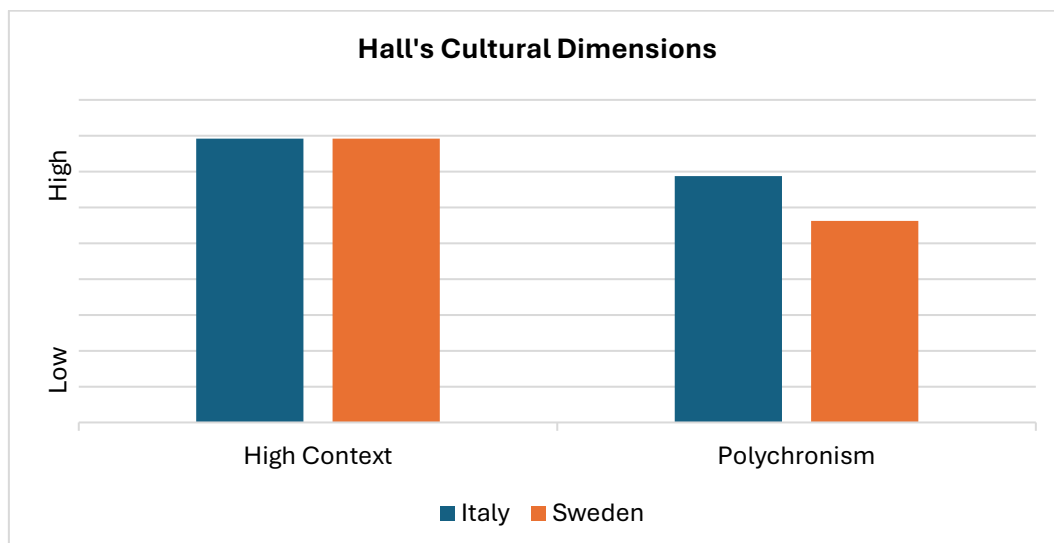
Table 6: Hall's Cultural Dimensions – High Context & Polychronism

(Italy = theoretically higher-context / more polychronic than Sweden)

	Italy (0–2)	Sweden (0–2)	Δ (IT–SE)	Theory predicts	Alignment
High-Context	1.58	1.58	0.00	IT > SE	✗ No differentiation
Visual richness / density	1.50	1.25	+0.25		Slight IT > SE ✓
Multimedia / motion	1.50	1.75	-0.25		Reversed ✗
Layered / non-linear structure	1.75	1.75	0.00		Identical
Polychronism	1.38	1.13	+0.25	IT > SE	✓ Weak alignment
Multi-Stimulus Environment	1.00	0.50	+0.50		IT > SE ✓
Layered / Non-Linear Structure	1.75	1.75	0.00		Identical

Hall's dimensions are merely comparative, and scores should not be analyzed in isolation. Figure 5 provides a comparative visualization of the scores, which harmonizes with this notion. The high context vs. low context dimension shows no observable difference between the two countries. Websites across cultures are equally rich, layered, and multimedia-heavy. There is directional consistency in the polychronism vs. monochronism dimension. However, the difference is only minor ($\Delta = 0.25$), which indicates weak alignment with the theoretical foundation. This suggests that modern web design elements, such as rich media and dynamic layouts, have become a global standard that overrides Hall's cultural communication framework, at least in European digital contexts. The coding framework needs further development to account for this evolution.

Figure 5: Relative Scores of High Context and Polychronism from Observations



Website Element Sensitivity

Table 7 shows the cultural sensitivity of each website element analyzed. Sensitivity is defined as the mean delta between Italy and Sweden across each website indicator. In other words, the table illustrates which elements are adapted the most and which are standardized. Table 8 illustrates results with and without the near-fully standardized company IKEA to provide a robustness check.

Table 7: Indicator Sensitivity to Localization

(All 22 indicators | 5 brands (Volkswagen, Verisure, Wix, Deloitte, IKEA) | Markets: Italy vs. Sweden | Ranked from most to least localized)

Dim.	Indicator	Mean IT	Mean SE	$ \Delta $	Sensitivity
PDI	Prestige / leadership claims	0.20	0.80	0.60	HIGH
MAS	Male-dominant imagery	1.20	0.80	0.40	HIGH
POL	Multi-Stimulus Environment	1.20	0.80	0.40	HIGH
HC	Visual richness / density	1.45	1.20	0.25	MOD
MAS	Performance emphasis	1.00	1.20	0.20	MOD
PDI	Institutional credibility	0.80	1.00	0.20	MOD
IDV	Individual imagery	0.80	1.00	0.20	MOD
MAS	Achievement language	0.60	0.80	0.20	MOD
MAS	Competitive framing	0.00	0.20	0.20	MOD
UAI	Help/support visibility	1.60	1.40	0.20	MOD
UAI	Navigation clarity	1.80	2.00	0.20	MOD
UAI	Process explanation	1.40	1.60	0.20	MOD
LTO	Search / structured discovery	1.40	1.60	0.20	MOD
HC	Multimedia / motion	1.60	1.80	0.20	MOD
PDI	Leadership / authority visibility	0.20	0.20	0.00	NONE
IDV	Individual benefit framing	1.80	1.80	0.00	NONE
UAI	Trial/guarantee mechanisms	1.20	1.20	0.00	NONE
LTO	Information depth	2.00	2.00	0.00	NONE
LTO	Future-oriented messaging	0.80	0.80	0.00	NONE
LTO	Stability/sustainability framing	0.60	0.60	0.00	NONE
HC	Layered / non-linear structure	1.80	1.80	0.00	NONE
POL	Layered / Non-Linear Structure	1.40	1.40	0.00	NONE

The indicators showed different levels of localization categorized in three degrees of sensitivity: high, moderate, and none (nonexistent). Prestige/leadership claims, individual imagery, male-dominant-imagery show significant degrees of localization (Mean $|\Delta| \geq 0.4$). 11 elements show weak divergence ($0 > \text{Mean } |\Delta| < 0.4$), but not enough to outright order localization. These should be A/B tested for optimal cultural

resonance. 8 universally standardized website elements are identical across the two countries (counting Layered / Non-Linear Structure twice).

A robustness check is introduced in Table 8 to analyze how the scores of the near-fully standardized company IKEA potentially dilute the scores.

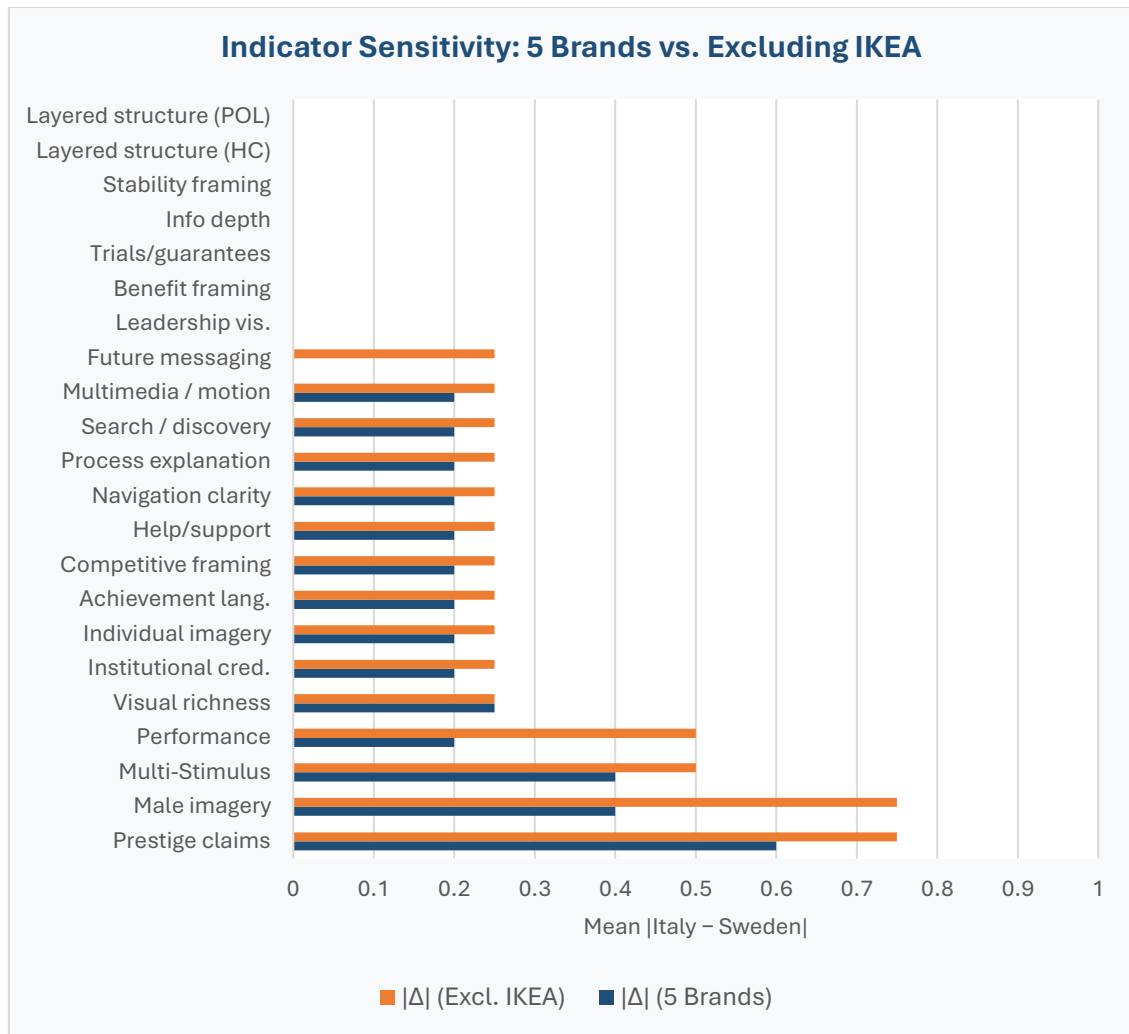
Table 8: Indicator Sensitivity & Robustness Check

All 22 indicators | 5 brands (Volkswagen, Verisure, Wix, Deloitte, IKEA) | Markets: Italy vs. Sweden

FULL ANALYSIS (5 BRANDS)						ROBUSTNESS CHECK (EXCLUDING IKEA)				
Dim.	Indicator	Mean IT	Mean SE	Δ	Sensitivity	Mean IT	Mean SE	Δ	Sensitivity	Robust?
PDI	Prestige / leadership claims	0.20	0.80	0.60	HIGH	0.25	1.00	0.75	HIGH	Confirmed
MAS	Male-dominant imagery	1.20	0.80	0.40	HIGH	1.50	0.75	0.75	HIGH	Confirmed
POL	Multi-Stimulus Environment	1.20	0.80	0.40	HIGH	1.00	0.50	0.50	HIGH	Confirmed
MAS	Performance emphasis	1.00	1.20	0.20	MOD	1.00	1.50	0.50	HIGH	Stronger
HC	Visual richness / density	1.45	1.20	0.25	MOD	1.50	1.25	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
PDI	Institutional credibility	0.80	1.00	0.20	MOD	1.00	1.25	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
IDV	Individual imagery	0.80	1.00	0.20	MOD	0.75	1.00	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
MAS	Achievement language	0.60	0.80	0.20	MOD	0.75	1.00	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
MAS	Competitive framing	0.00	0.20	0.20	MOD	0.00	0.25	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
UAI	Help/support visibility	1.60	1.40	0.20	MOD	1.50	1.25	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
UAI	Navigation clarity	1.80	2.00	0.20	MOD	1.75	2.00	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
UAI	Process explanation	1.40	1.60	0.20	MOD	1.25	1.50	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
LTO	Search / structured discovery	1.40	1.60	0.20	MOD	1.25	1.50	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
HC	Multimedia / motion	1.60	1.80	0.20	MOD	1.50	1.75	0.25	MOD	Confirmed
PDI	Leadership / authority visibility	0.20	0.20	0.00	NONE	0.25	0.25	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
IDV	Individual benefit framing	1.80	1.80	0.00	NONE	2.00	2.00	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
UAI	Trial/guarantee mechanisms	1.20	1.20	0.00	NONE	1.25	1.25	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
LTO	Information depth	2.00	2.00	0.00	NONE	2.00	2.00	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
LTO	Future-oriented messaging	0.80	0.80	0.00	NONE	0.75	1.00	0.25	MOD	Shifts up
LTO	Stability/sustainability framing	0.60	0.60	0.00	NONE	0.75	0.75	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
HC	Layered / non-linear structure	1.80	1.80	0.00	NONE	1.75	1.75	0.00	NONE	Confirmed
POL	Layered / Non-Linear Structure (POL)	1.40	1.40	0.00	NONE	1.75	1.75	0.00	NONE	Confirmed

Mean sensitivity across all five brands is 0.14. However, when IKEA is excluded, the mean jumps to 0.23. Two indicators switch classification when this change is incorporated. Future-oriented messaging goes from 0 to 0.25, which means that it becomes a moderately sensitive element. Performance emphasis hikes from 0.2 to 0.5, which turns the indicator into a high-sensitivity one.

Figure 6: Indicator Sensitivity: 5 Brands vs. Excluding IKEA



The sensitivity, including and excluding IKEA, is visualized in Figure 6 and clearly isolates the degrees of localization in clusters. The strongest finding is the top three distinctly localized elements: male imagery, multi-stimulus environment, and prestige claims, which remain the most sensitive elements regardless of the two samples.

Theoretical and Managerial Implications

This section reconnects the above results to the theoretical foundation and provides actionable insights for managers.

How do brands currently balance global brand consistency with cultural adaptation?

The analysis reveals three distinct strategies for localization/standardization. None of the brands applies a full or high localization approach, and even the most adapted websites show merely minor adjustments.

Firstly, full standardization is used by IKEA and Deloitte. These brands show near-identical websites across Italy and Sweden, and their strategies prioritize global brand image and operational efficiency over cultural adaptation across all touchpoints. However, given that this study does not assess performance outcomes, their use of standardized websites cannot be interpreted as evidence that this approach does not negatively affect results.

Secondly, selective localization is applied by Volkswagen and Wix. These brands standardize core site structure, navigation, and User Experience (UX). Localization comes in only in areas they believe produce the highest impact. This strategy can be likened to an “80/20” approach. Brands standardize 80% of the website elements (where cultural differences make a huge difference) and localize the 2-3 elements where data shows a significant impact.

Thirdly, a broader localization approach is implemented by Verisure. This brand shows the greatest degree of localization out of the sample, with indications of stronger adaptation in the PDI, IDV, and MAS dimensions. The home security sector is characterized by high involvement and high trust because purchasing decisions require extensive evaluation and depend on perceived security, privacy, and risk (Gebsumbut et al., 2025; Shuhaiber et al., 2023). To target consumers effectively, security products need deep local trust indicators through the “right” imagery, authority language, and gender representation for the local culture.

Which of Hofstede’s and Hall’s dimensions are most important to localize in website communication?

From the results of the analysis, the dimensions can be ranked in the following order, from most important to least important to localize: MAS, PDI, POL, IDV, LTO, UAI, and HC. However, within every dimension, some elements localize, and others standardize. Therefore, the critical nuance seems to lie more in each element than in the dimensions themselves. Ergo, the most actionable framework is not dimension-based; rather, it is element-based and is visualized in Table 9 below.

Which marketing elements are most sensitive to cultural differences?

There are only three indicators that remain at high sensitivity regardless of sample composition, making them the most robust localization candidates. A finding that reinforces previous research (Nizamani et al., 2025) is that sensitivity seems to be

dependent on whether an element is functional or symbolic in nature. Functional UX elements and explicit messaging are universal, while elements related to visual identity and implicit cultural signals differ. This illustrates that culture in web design manifests more through what is shown (imagery, visual density, and prestige cues) than through what is said (benefit language, information structure) or how a website works (navigation, search, trials).

How should companies decide which marketing elements to standardize vs. localize across European cultures?

Table 9 shows a decision framework that has been developed using the findings from the analysis. The framework aims to help managers understand what elements of websites to localize, standardize, and research further to understand what fits their specific contexts to maximize effectiveness in communication and minimize costs.

Table 9: Decision Framework – What to Standardize vs. Localize

(Based on empirical evidence from this study: which website elements should managers standardize vs. localize across European cultures?)

⚠ LOCALIZE (3 elements — HIGH sensitivity in both analyses)				
Element	Dim.	Evidence	Δ (5 brands)	Δ (excl. IKEA)
Prestige / status claims	PDI	SE uses more prestige claims (counterintuitive vs. Hofstede). Robust across both samples.	0.60	0.75
Male-dominant imagery	MAS	IT male imagery significantly higher (1.50 vs 0.75 excl. IKEA). Largest raw score gap.	0.40	0.75
Multi-Stimulus Environment	POL	IT shows more simultaneous visual stimuli (animations, pop-ups), consistent with polychronic theory.	0.40	0.50

✅ STANDARDIZE GLOBALLY (6 indicators* — Δ = 0 in both analyses)				
Element	Dim.	Evidence	Δ (5 brands)	Δ (excl. IKEA)
Individual benefit framing	IDV	Identical (1.80/1.80 with IKEA; 2.00/2.00 without). Universal "you"-framing. Δ = 0 in both.	0.00	0.00
Information depth	LTO	Maximum score (2.00/2.00) in both markets, both samples. A digital expectation, not cultural.	0.00	0.00
Trial / guarantee mechanisms	UAI	Zero variation in both samples. Risk-reduction is universal regardless of UAI scores.	0.00	0.00
Stability / sustainability framing	LTO	Zero variation in both samples (0.60/0.60 with IKEA; 0.75/0.75 without).	0.00	0.00
Layered / non-linear structure	HC/POL	Identical in both markets (1.80/1.80 and 1.75/1.75). Used for both HC and POL dimensions.	0.00	0.00
Leadership / authority visibility	PDI	Near-zero in both markets (0.20/0.20). CEO presence is a brand choice, not cultural.	0.00	0.00

** Layered / non-linear structure counts as 1 indicator but they appear in both the HC and POL dimensions.*

🔍 MONITOR (12 elements — context-dependent, sensitivity varies by sample)				
Element	Dim.	Evidence	Δ (5 brands)	Δ (excl. IKEA)
Performance emphasis	MAS	SE shows more performance messaging. IKEA masks this: Δ rises from 0.20 to 0.50 without IKEA. Sample-dependent.	0.20	0.50
Future-oriented messaging	LTO	Δ = 0 with IKEA but rises to 0.25 without. Classification shifts based on sample composition. Test per brand.	0.00	0.25
Visual richness / density	HC	Small but stable Δ = 0.25 in both samples. Directionally IT > SE. Low impact, but worth monitoring.	0.25	0.25
Individual imagery	IDV	SE uses more individual imagery. Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. Borderline; sector-dependent.	0.20	0.25
Institutional credibility	PDI	SE slightly higher credibility claims. Δ = 0.20/0.25. May matter more for B2B or trust-dependent services.	0.20	0.25
Achievement language	MAS	Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. Small but consistent difference; SE uses slightly more achievement-oriented copy.	0.20	0.25
Competitive framing	MAS	Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. SE uses slightly more competitive language. Very low base scores in both markets.	0.20	0.25
Help / support visibility	UAI	Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. IT slightly higher help visibility. Small practical variation.	0.20	0.25
Navigation clarity	UAI	Near-identical (1.80/2.00). Small gap is practical UX variation. Δ ≤ 0.25 in both samples.	0.20	0.25
Process explanation	UAI	Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. SE marginally higher process transparency. Consistent but small.	0.20	0.25
Search / structured discovery	LTO	Δ = 0.20 / 0.25. SE slightly more search tools. Small difference, consistent direction.	0.20	0.25
Multimedia / motion	HC	Near-identical (1.60/1.80). Rich media is a global web standard, but small gap persists.	0.20	0.25

The 22-indicator analysis with robustness check reveals a decision model with three tiers: 3 elements to localize, 6 (7 if counting Layered / non-linear structure in both HC and POL dimensions) to standardize, and 12 to monitor depending on context. Only indicators with $|\Delta| \geq 0.40$ in both analyses qualify for the localization category, and only those with $|\Delta| = 0$ in both qualify for the standardization category. The large “Monitor” category indicates that most website elements and communication are not clearly cultural or universal. They depend on a brand’s strategy, sector, and sample composition.

This framework entails that companies that wish to expand their customer base from Italy to Sweden or vice versa should localize website elements related to Prestige/status claims, Male-dominant imagery, Multi-Stimulus Environment, and Performance emphasis. A standardization approach can be applied to Individual benefit framing, Information depth, Trial / guarantee mechanisms, Stability / sustainability

framing, Layered / non-linear structure, Leadership / authority visibility, Navigation clarity, Multimedia / motion.

These findings reinforce the prior research that argues for a hybrid strategy. Most of the elements are in a gray zone where optimal recommendations depend on context. However, the extremes are clear: functional UX and textual strategies are safer to assume universality around. Visual and prestige signaling seem to demand localization.

What are the risks of over-localizing vs. under-localizing?

The data shows that IKEA and Deloitte have almost identical websites across Italy and Sweden. At the same time, both are highly successful businesses operating in the upper echelons of competitiveness. This may indicate that standardization of cultural elements of website communication is a viable and perhaps even optimal strategy for brands with a strong global presence. Localizing the elements that the framework suggests are universal would strain the localization budget without any evidence of expected return. The Monitor category of this framework represents a potential over-localization trap. Indicators in this category show minor differences that plausibly reflect brand strategy rather than cultural differences. Localizing all 12 indicators in the Monitor category based on negligible scores risks: (a) diluting the brand image and confusing the international consumer base, (b) escalating localization costs (which multiply across all markets) without proper potential for ROI, (c) optimizing strategy for cultural distinctions that may not even play a role in conversion or engagement. A prime example of this risk is the MAS dimension, which, although still ambiguous, at first glance leans more towards the standardization classification ($|\Delta|=0.20$). However, when the robustness check is introduced, this dimension finds itself in the localization category ($|\Delta|=0.50$). Executing on either of these two interpretations without further analysis of context could lead to uneducated and disadvantageous decisions.

The three “Localize” elements are associated with a great amount of under-localization risk. The data show that only prestige claims, male-dominated imagery, and multi-stimulus environment have sensitivity scores high enough ($|\Delta| \geq 0.40$) to be robust across both analyses. Hence, under-localizing these aspects creates the highest risk for cultural dissonance. These elements operate through implicit visual codes, and under-localization can therefore lead to cultural dissonance, where users perceive the website as less relatable or less appealing. However, as seen in Figure 4, brands systemically

under-localize compared to Hofstede's theory. Only one dimension is directionally consistent with the literature. Therefore, the risk of under-localization may be lower in European digital contexts than what the theory suggests. This could be explained as digital UX praxes and global brand standards have created a new foundation of consumer expectations that Hofstede's framework is unable to account for. After all, the theory was developed using workplace-based research before the digitalization of the world.

The asymmetry of the risk implies a conservative localization strategy. Under-localizing three elements comes with risk, but this risk is somewhat limited and merely connected to cultural dissonance on certain visual aspects. Over-localizing the "Monitor" elements entails a smaller and scattered risk that compounds across markets. The optimal strategy is to localize the three identified elements, standardize the seven universal elements, and adopt an empirical approach to test the other 12 "Monitor" elements' cultural sensitivity in specific market contexts.

Limitations

Perhaps the most limiting factor of this study is the small sample size. In a comparative case analysis, it is nearly impossible to reach a sample size large enough to fully be able to generalize the findings. The strengths, instead, lie in the depth of analysis.

The sample selection is another limitation. When using a small sample, the selection of said sample is more crucial than in a large-scale study. A small sample leaves room for bias to emerge, and a minor selection misstep may lead to large skewing of the results. That said, the implemented robustness checks confirmed that no single brand led to a substantial skewing of the results—only minor fine-tuning adjustments. The brands also operate in substantially different sectors. Therefore, this study is unable to account for industry differences that manifest in digital communication.

While Italy and Sweden diverge significantly according to Hofstede and Hall, they converge on many other factors, such as membership in Western Europe and the EU, high GDP, and well-established digital literacy and infrastructure. For example, the findings about how functional UX elements are standardized across cultures may not apply to countries that differ more in the aforementioned aspects.

The 22 indicators were scored by a single individual. However, best practices imply that inter-rater reliability cannot be established without a second independent coder, which may lead to systematic coder bias (Krippendorff, 2019). While the coding framework was adapted to maximize objectivity, some of the indicators analyzed (and communication by nature) involve subjective judgements that can vary between coders. The small $|\Delta|$ differences driving most “Monitor” classifications (0.20–0.25) are well within the range that coder noise alone could produce.

Website content was analyzed at a single point in time, but brands regularly run seasonal campaigns or tests that may change the UX. This could lead to one country having the “standard” version of a website and the other having a seasonal or test version, which may skew the results. Therefore, longitudinal shifts are not represented in this analysis.

Only a limited number of pages were evaluated for each website. This neglects the potential localization pattern in the “deeper” pages. A brand that standardizes its homepage may heavily localize its checkout and vice versa. Hence, the current scope likely underestimates the overall degree of localization each brand applies. Moreover, the fact that brands use different navigation structures makes the selection of these pages subjective and somewhat unreliable.

The study reports merely what brands do, and not what actually works. Therefore, there is no causal link between the observations and how the brands perform. A brand may be under-localizing on a high-sensitivity indicator and still outperform a competitor that localizes heavily. Without data about the outcome, the framework recommendations solely rely on observed practices and theory. There is no evidence about what either strategy does to performance.

As briefly mentioned in the literature review, Hofstede’s and Hall’s theories have their limitations. Hofstede’s theory was developed from IBM employee surveys (1967–1973) using workplace values and not digital consumer behavior. By finding that only 1 of the 5 observed dimensions aligns with theory, the analysis shows that this framework underperforms. Therefore, the findings in this report are limited by the applicability of the theories in the context of digital communication. Furthermore, treating Italy and Sweden as two completely homogeneous entities disregards their internal cultural

contrasts. Hall rightfully highlights the difference between Northern and Southern Italy (see table 2; Van Everdingen & Waarts, 2003).

Future Research Recommendations

Future research should focus on expanding the sample to 25+ and dividing the sample by sector. The “Monitor” category of the decision framework calls for context-specific adjustments; hence, there is a need for further context-specific analysis. Additionally, increasing the sample size and analyzing by sector would make robustness checks within each sector possible and further strengthen the validity.

Going beyond this two-country analysis to encompass 6 or more countries would provide insights about the whole range of Hofstede’s and Hall’s dimensions. This would further test if the hypothesis about functional vs. symbolic elements, UAI’s standardization in Western Europe, and the 3 localization recommendations apply globally.

Introduce at least one independent coder and check intercoder reliability (with Krippendorff’s (2019) α). As for the indicators that are largely subjective, consider using a bigger sample of coders.

To back up the analysis with performance data (e.g. conversion rate, bounce rate, time-on-site, add-to-cart) would turn the framework from descriptive to prescriptive by explaining not only what brands do but what actually works.

Evaluating website elements over a longer period of time (e.g. quarterly over a 12-24 month period) separates seasonal changes, may minimize variation driven by campaigns and tests, and shows longitudinal shifts in localization.

Examining the customer funnel in greater detail by analyzing a larger sample of pages per website would provide insights about which stages of the customer journey are most valuable to localize. A hypothesis is that localization follows a U-curve with a higher degree in the awareness stage (home page) and at the transaction stage (checkout), while the stages/pages in between those show lower localization efforts. A study like this would help better understand budget allocation.

Content analysis of what brands publish only provides one perspective of the subject matter. Integrating testing with real users (e.g. eye-tracking, A/B tests,

qualitative interviews) determines whether the 3 localization recommendations produce the predicted results.

Discovering that only 2 out of the 7 studied dimensions suggests that Hofstede's and Hall's frameworks may not be the optimal lens to study this kind of digital communication through. Future research should compare results with GLOBE (House et al., 2004), Schwartz value dimensions, Inglehart's World Values Survey clusters, and Minkov's revised cultural maps. A framework designed specifically for and from website data (and not workplace research) may provide a better explanation of digital communication choices.

Conclusion

This study examined how companies balance standardization and localization of website communication across Italy and Sweden. The aim was to go beyond theory and provide actionable insights for managers about website elements. The report shows a strong bias towards standardization. Most brands express low levels of localization, and even the most localized brand in the sample is highly standardized. This suggests that standardization is the norm and localization is cautiously implemented. Cultural differences do not manifest in how entire websites are designed. Rather, culture is embodied through minor and specific elemental shifts. Moreover, there is a clear pattern that symbolic and visual elements are localized, while functional and UX elements are standardized.

This paper's biggest contribution is the three-tier decision model. It recommends localizing three indicators: prestige/status claims, male-dominant imagery, and multi-stimulus environment. Six elements favor standardization: individual benefit framing, information depth, trial/guarantee mechanisms, stability/sustainability framing, layered/non-linear structure, and leadership/authority visibility. 12 indicators need to be monitored to understand their implications in the specific context of the brand they are applied to: performance emphasis, future-oriented messaging, visual richness/density, individual imagery, institutional credibility, achievement language, competitive framing, help/support visibility, navigation clarity, process explanation, search/structured discovery, and multimedia/motion. Rather than trying to localize all aspects, brands should focus on the aforementioned highest impact elements.

The alignment with Hofstede's and Hall's frameworks is weak, which suggests that traditional culture theories do not fully transfer to modern-day digital contexts. Universally accepted UX standards may hamper divergence in website communication.

Companies should avoid full localization because it is costly and may not always yield proportional benefits. Simultaneously, they should avoid full standardization since it misses important cultural signals. The best strategy is to localize high-impact elements, standardize core UX features, and test the rest with A/B testing.

Over-localization risks brand dilution, investment without ROI, and optimizing for cultural differences that are not present in every context. Under-localization, on the other hand, may lead to cultural dissonance, and the website subconsciously becomes

unattractive to some users. On an aggregate level, over-localization seems to possess the bigger risk; thus, a strategic approach should implement localization conservatively.

Even though Italy and Sweden are significantly segregated in Hofstede's and Hall's theories, in digital behavior, the countries seem to converge to a large degree. This could imply that there are European standards that disregard or dilute cultural differences.

This study contributes to the field by transforming theory into a practical decision framework. This adds to a limited body of work of localization frameworks that provide recommendations about website elements.

In an increasingly globalized digital world, the question is no longer whether to localize or not, but where it actually matters most to adapt. As digital standards continue to converge, culture does not disappear, but instead reimagines itself and manifests in unfamiliar fashions. The evidence suggests that success does not come from effectively choosing between standardization and localization, but in mastering the harmony between the two.

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Appendix

Appendix 1: Table 3: Adaptations and Justifications for Adaptations of Capece and Di Pillo's (2023) Hofstede and Hall Website Coding Framework

Original (Capece & Di Pillo, 2023)	New	What it Observes	Why keep/adapt	Justification
Power Distance Index				
Leaders (% of sites that represent CEOs and top management).	Leadership / authority visibility	CEO, founder, expert, executive presence	Keep concept, modernize "leaders"	Logical adaptation, Singh & Matsuo (2004): authority & rank signaling
Titles and Prizes (% of sites that present titles and prizes).	Institutional credibility	Awards, certifications, major client logos, partner logos	Keeps "titles and prizes" idea in modern form	Singh & Matsuo (2004): awards, quality assurance, prestige indicators
Monumental Building (% of sites that represent Monumental Building).	Prestige / leadership claims	"Leader," "trusted by industry," "#1"	Keeps hierarchy/status logic	Singh & Matsuo (2004): prestige, rank, and institutional signals; Cyr (2013): visual design adapts but meaning persists
Individualism Index				
Individual Images (calculated as the ratio of individual images to the total of images depicting people). For this indicator, we considered only one element because it is the most representative of the cultural marker of individualism.	Individual imagery	One person alone, individual use scenes	Keep original core logic	Singh & Matsuo (2004): awards, quality assurance, prestige indicators
	Individual benefit framing	"Your success," "your website," "your goals"	Light adaptation from visual-only to message framing	Cruz et al. (2017): more collectivistic consumers tend to subordinate their own personal goals to the goals of their in-groups. Less collectivistic consumers, on the other hand, subordinate in-group goals to their own personal goals. Findings: Using "you" (as opposed to not using it) is effective for individualist cultures.
Motivation Toward Achievement and Success Index				
Men Images (calculated as the ratio of images of men compared to the total images of people). Also for this indicator, we	Male-dominant imagery	Men shown alone or as primary actors	Keep original indicator	

considered only one element because it is the most representative of the cultural marker of masculinity.				
	Achievement language	Success, winning, growth, performance	Small adaptation supported by older masculinity literature	Hofstede defines masculinity in terms of achievement, assertiveness, and material success, not only male presence. So adding achievement-focused wording is a direct way to operationalize the same construct in modern marketing cop
	Competitive framing	"Outperform," "be the best," "lead"	Modern expression of masculine-coded achievement	Hofstede defines masculinity in terms of achievement, assertiveness, and material success, not only male presence. So adding achievement-focused wording is a direct way to operationalize the same construct in modern marketing cop
	Performance emphasis	Efficiency, results, effectiveness	Keeps the same achievement orientation	Competitive language is a direct textual expression of masculinity in Hofstede's model, where higher masculinity cultures emphasize winning, success, and competition. This is a small and defensible extension when websites no longer rely mainly on gender imagery.
Uncertainty Avoidance Index				
Help in customer experience (the sum of the percentage of the sites that show the contacts of the local dealers, the toll-free number, and the FAQs)	Help/support visibility	FAQ, chat, contact, customer service	Keeps original "help" logic. Adapts toll-free number to customer service	
Site Map (% of sites that have the site map)	Navigation clarity	Clear menus, structured pathways, easy next steps	Modern replacement for site map emphasis	Site maps rarely posted. The function of a site map (orientation + structure) is now fulfilled by: clear menus, guided flows, structured pathways. Hofstede: UAI reflects discomfort with ambiguity → need for structured environments
Free Downloads (% of sites that give the possibility to carry out free downloads).	Trial/guarantee mechanisms	Free trial, cancel anytime, refunds, free downloads	Modern replacement for "free downloads"	Singh & Matsou (2004) mention free trials and downloads. Capece & Di Pillo (2023) use free downloads as a proxy for: reducing risk, allowing evaluation before commitment. Today, digital products are rarely downloadable PDFs/software anymore. The modern equivalent are free trial, no commitment, easy cancellation, refund guarantees. So same

				psychological function is applied using a different mechanism.
	Process explanation	"How it works," step-by-step onboarding	Captures reassurance and predictability	This is a defensible modernization of guided navigation and help structures. High uncertainty-avoidance contexts value guidance, predictability, and reduced ambiguity, so "how it works" flows and step-by-step explanation fit the original construct well. Singh & Matsuo (2004) already connect UAI to customer service and guided navigation, and later web-design research links navigation and information structure to trust and usability. Cyr 2013, trust and culture.
Long-Term Orientation Index				
Search Bar (% of sites that have the search bar); Site Map (% of sites that have the site map); Index page (% of sites that have the index page)	Search / structured discovery tools	Search bar, structured menus, filtering	Keep concept. Site maps and index pages are rarely displayed to the public anymore.	
FAQs (% of sites that have the FAQs).	Information depth	FAQ, explanatory content, layered details	Keeps planning/structured information logic	
	Future-oriented messaging	Build for the future, long-term growth, enduring value	Small justified update	
	Stability/sustainability framing (excluding direct references to environmental sustainability)	Reliable, long-lasting, strategic investment	Modern extension of long-term thinking	Singh & Matsuo (2004) already link masculinity to "product effectiveness," including durability, quality, and robustness. Expanding this to performance emphasis preserves the same logic in a more contemporary form.
High Context				
Complex Menus (% of sites that have complex menus); Banner (% of sites that have one or more banners)	Visual richness / density	Dense page, many visual layers, expressive design	Modern version of banners/animations/complexity	Würtz (2006) argues that high-context websites rely more on visual effects and context-rich presentation to communicate meaning, which supports coding density and richness rather than one specific page component.

Animations (% of sites that have animations regarding sounds, videos, texts, and images);	Multimedia / motion	Video, animation, movement, dynamic hero sections	Keeps animation logic, modernization	
Scrollbar (% of sites that have scrollbars).	Layered / non-linear structure	Multiple paths, rich sections, more exploratory flow	Modern form of complex menus / scrollbar logic	Würtz (2006) demonstrates that high-context cultures (closely related to polychronic tendencies) use less linear, more immersive, and visually layered website structures.
Polychronism				
Animations (% of sites that have animations regarding sounds, videos, texts, and images);	Multi-Stimulus Environment	Presence of more than one simultaneous visual and interactive elements (animations, video, banners, pop-ups, moving components)	Slight modernization	Hall (1976): Polychronic time orientation emphasizes managing multiple stimuli and activities simultaneously. "Animations" alone is too narrow and no longer discriminative. "Multi-stimulus environment" preserves the original intent while reflecting contemporary web design.
Absence of Site Map (% of sites that do not have site map).	Layered / Non-Linear Structure	Multiple paths, rich sections, more exploratory flow	Modern form of complex menus / scrollbar logic	Hall's framework distinguishes polychronic systems as fluid, overlapping, and less structured, where meaning is embedded across multiple channels rather than delivered sequentially. Würtz (2006) demonstrates that high-context cultures (closely related to polychronic tendencies) use less linear, more immersive, and visually layered website structures.

Appendix 2: Website Page URLs

Company	Home / Landing Page	Pricing/purchase/booking page	Product / Service Page	Trust / Support Page	Date Visited
Wix Italy	https://it.wix.com/	https://it.wix.com/premium-purchase-plan/dynamo	https://it.wix.com/website/design	https://support.wix.com/it	05 apr 2026
Wix Sweden	https://sv.wix.com/	https://sv.wix.com/premium-purchase-plan/dynamo	https://sv.wix.com/website/design	https://support.wix.com/en	05 apr 2026
Verisure Italy	https://www.verisure.it/	https://www.verisure.it/antifurto-casa/costi	https://www.verisure.it/antifurto-casa	https://www.verisure.it/consigli-e-assistenza/domande-frequenti	05 apr 2026
Verisure Sweden	https://www.verisure.se/	https://www.verisure.se/produkter-tjanster/overvakningskamera/arlo-video-doorbell	https://www.verisure.se/produkter-tjanster	https://www.verisure.se/hjelp	05 apr 2026
Volkswagen Italy	https://www.volkswagen.it/it.html	https://www.volkswagen.it/it/modelli/nuova-golf.html	https://www.volkswagen.it/it/area-clienti.html	https://www.volkswagen.it/it/guida-una-volkswagen/usato-certificato/faq.html	05 apr 2026
Volkswagen Sweden	https://www.volkswagen.se/sv.html	https://www.volkswagen.se/sv/modeller/golf.html#configurate	https://www.volkswagen.se/sv/modeller/alla-kategorier.html	https://www.volkswagen.se/sv/elbilar/fragor-och-svar.html	05 apr 2026
Deloitte Italy	https://www.deloitte.com/it/it.html	https://www.deloitte.com/it/it/what-we-do.html	https://www.deloitte.com/it/it/services.html	https://www.deloitte.com/it/it/our-thinking.html?icid=top_o-ur-thinking	05 apr 2026

Deloitte Sweden	https://www.deloitte.com/se/sv.html	https://www.deloitte.com/se/sv/what-we-do.html?icid=top_what-we-do	https://www.deloitte.com/se/sv/services.html	https://www.deloitte.com/se/sv/our-thinking.html?icid=top_our-thinking	05 apr 2026
IKEA Italy	https://www.ikea.com/it/it/	https://www.ikea.com/it/it/p/naemmaroe-tavolo-da-giardino-mordente-marrone-chiaro-00510308/	https://www.ikea.com/it/it/rooms/kitchen/	https://www.ikea.com/it/it/customer-service/faq/	09 apr 2026
IKEA Sweden	https://www.ikea.com/se/sv/	https://www.ikea.com/se/sv/p/naemmaroe-bord-utomhus-ljusbrunlaserad-00510308/	https://www.ikea.com/se/sv/rooms/kitchen/	https://www.ikea.com/se/sv/customer-service/faq/	09 apr 2026